

01

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: NATURE, OBJECT AND EPISTEMIC PROBLEM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Its philosophy examines phenomenological features, the alleged object, evidential force, interpretive mediation and the possibility of naturalistic explanation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A subject undergoes an affective or cognitive episode, interprets it through a religious framework and then treats it as disclosure, encounter or transformation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The experience can justify commitment for the subject while remaining contestable as intersubjective evidence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not infer a metaphysical object solely from phenomenological intensity, neurological correlation or the sincerity of testimony.

ANSWER LINE: Religious experience may transform the subject, but its private force does not automatically become public proof of the reality it appears to disclose.

02

WESTERN ACCOUNTS OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Religion for James is personal before institutional; the experience of the "MORE" connects the self, through the subconscious, to a wider reality.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

PRIMARY / DEFINING (the two that settle the classification) Ineffability — the state defies adequate expression; its quality must be directly experienced, and, like a feeling rather than a proposition, it cannot be imparted to those who have not had it.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Reproduce this grading; do not present a flat list of four.

ANSWER LINE: Mystical experience is a mode of religious experience marked, for William James, primarily by ineffability and noetic quality.

03

INDIAN ACCOUNTS OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Religious experience is integral intuition — a knowing that unites, higher than sense & reason. □.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Anubhava (direct realisation): in Indian thought the highest religious experience is immediate, intuitive realisation (anubhava/aparokṣānubhūti), not mere belief — the goal of the whole spiritual path. □
Advaita (2024 PYQ) — features: □ Non-dual (nirvikalpa) experience — the collapse of subject–object duality; the realiser is Brahman ("aham brahmāsmi").

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Self-certifying (svataḥ-siddha), beyond objectifying speech (avācya; yato vāco nivartante), bliss (ānanda), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition. □□ Terminological discipline: do not call this experience anirvacanīya.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

In Advaita's technical vocabulary anirvacanīya is the status of māyā and the world-appearance (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa), not of Brahman or of the realisation of Brahman — see Religious Language §9.5 and Notions of God §2.

ANSWER LINE: Advaitic aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation) is direct recognition of the identity of ātman (the true self) and Brahman (ultimate reality).

04

THE OBJECT AND VERIDICALITY OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Hick's pluralist reply: the various experiences are culturally-shaped responses to one ultimate "Real" ("the Real an sich" experienced through different lenses). □ Mystical experience & revelation (2023 PYQ): mystical experience can be a vehicle of revelation (God/the Real disclosed experientially) — non-propositional revelation; the two are intimately linked. □□.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Is religious experience veridical (of a real object) or merely subjective/psychological? □□ For veridicality: Principle of Credulity (Swinburne) — if it seems to one that X is present, probably X is, absent defeaters; the noetic quality; convergence of mystics.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Final verdict: Religious experience can justify the subject defeasibly, but it does not function as universally coercive proof.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: diversity of experiences across religions (which object is real?).

ANSWER LINE: Veridicality asks whether a religious experience presents a real object rather than only a psychologically genuine state.

05

MYSTICISM, NUMINOUS EXPERIENCE, PRAYER AND WORSHIP

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Mysticism seeks unitive or non-discursive awareness, the numinous combines fascination and dread, prayer addresses or attends to the sacred, and worship enacts reverence communally or ritually.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Different practices shape attention, emotion and interpretation, producing experiences understood as union, encounter, dependence, reverence or response.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The diversity of forms weakens any single evidential argument but strengthens a phenomenological account of religion as lived orientation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not equate prayer with mystical union or assume that every powerful religious emotion has the same alleged object.

ANSWER LINE: Religious experience ranges from extraordinary claims of union to ordinary practices of prayer and worship, so its nature must be classified before its truth is assessed.

JAMES, OTTO, ADVAITA AND FOUNDATIONAL POSITIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached by discursive reasoning alone. □ James's pragmatic method tests religious life by enduring fruits rather than dismissing it through causal origins. □ Otto names the Holy's distinctive phenomenology *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*. □ *Aham brahmāsmi* is an Upaniṣadic identity formula central to Advaitic interpretation. □□ Radhakrishnan gives direct spiritual intuition priority over its later doctrinal and institutional expressions.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The resulting consequence is that □ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached...

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not miss this limiting distinction: □ James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached...

ANSWER LINE: [James] "Nature & variety of religious experience per William James." (2022) → §1. [Advaita] "Main features of religious experience in Advaita Vedānta." (2024) → §2. [Radhakrishnan] "Nature & object of religious experience per Radhakrishnan." (2025) → §2. [Mystical-revelation] "Relation between mystical experience & revelation." (2023) → §3. [Veridicality] "Is religious experience a reliable ground for belief in God?" → §3 + §9.9. [Sacred/Holy] "'Sacred' and 'Holy' as generic names for the object of religion — can God be the object?" (2018, 20m) → §9.10. [Public discourse] "How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?" (2019, 15m) → §9.8. [Prayer/worship] "Distinguish prayer and worship and determine their place in religion." (2020, 15m) → §9.7 — two deliverables, both required. [Vedāntic] "Religious experience in the light of the Vedāntic tradition."

COMPARATIVE EVALUATION OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

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COMPARATIVE EVALUATION OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The comparison tests phenomenology, interpretive mediation, veridicality, testimony and naturalistic explanation across traditions without assuming one common metaphysics.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Each account moves from a reported experience through a conceptual interpretation to a claim about the sacred, ultimate reality or transformation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Cross-tradition comparison reveals recurring experiential structures while preserving major disagreements about object, ontology and evidential force.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Do not infer that phenomenological similarity proves metaphysical identity or that neural correlation by itself disproves religious interpretation.

ANSWER LINE: Religious experience is strongest as evidence of transformed consciousness and lived orientation, but weaker as coercive public proof of one disputed metaphysical object.